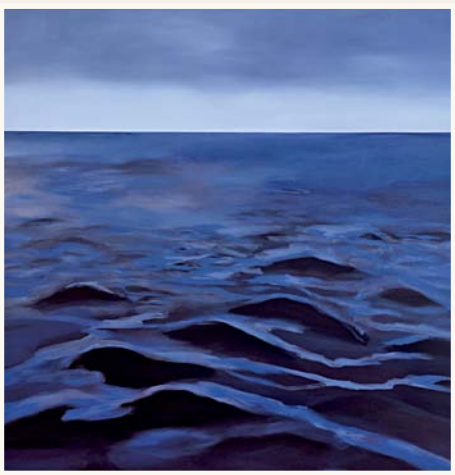










ART

THE SHAPE OF WATER

Kolkata's Experimenter gallery opens its doors in Mumbai with an Ayesha Sultana show that captures both fluidity and depth

PHOTOGRAPHY

IN THE PEOPLE'S STUDIO

KETAKI SHETH'S NEW EXHIBITION GIVES THE FADING PHOTO STUDIO NEW LIFE



What happens when photo studios—spaces that allowed easy travel to faraway lands—fade into obsolescence? Do they still carry the light of the past into the present? These seem to be some of the central questions that veteran photographer Ketaki Sheth's new exhibition *Photo Studio* (on display at Mumbai's Chemould Prescott Road till October 20) grapples with.

The genesis of this ambitious exhibition, Sheth tells us, started in 2014 when she discovered Jagdish Photo Studio in Manori, some 60 km north of Mumbai. The village has been Sheth's home for decades now—her father had built a house there before she was born. "I started photographing people in the village who were both familiar and new, and got particularly good pictures on festive occasions. I felt confident that I would find similar studios across the country and set off on the long journey across eight states over three years," she says.

Sheth eventually found 65 such studios across India. More than spaces that used digital backdrops of European monuments, Sheth found herself interested in barely surviving studios that kept the backdrops raw and hand-painted. Shot with lights already available in the studio, most of Sheth's images have a grainy, crackling beauty. "I wanted to keep things as natural and as close to the studio atmosphere as possible," she says. "[The images] do signal a passage of time, but I had to find those 65 studios before I knew for certain."

Clarifying that her project was never one of documenting studios, Sheth adds, "As a photographer, you choose the best pictures. I was setting

